CSIS AUSTRALIA CHAIR

Australia Daily Brief

Monday, November 2, 2026

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RE: Rabuka shelves Constitution Bill timetable · RBA tipped to lift to 4.85% · Albanese at CHOGM under fire at home · Pacific backs Marshall Islands nuclear claim · NZ early voting surges

ASX 200	AUD/USD	NZX 50	NZD/USD
8,856	0.7013	13,699	0.5623
+0.53%	-0.09%	-0.26%	-1.14%

IN THIS ISSUE Top Stories · Overnight · Stat · Pacific · New Zealand · China-Pacific · Canberra · Markets · Upcoming · The Wire

TODAY AT A GLANCE

1. Rabuka pulled the Constitution (Amendment) Bill 2026 off this week's parliamentary timetable one day after confirming he would table it, with no new date given and Fiji's election deadline fixed at February 6, 2027.
2. Markets and economists expect the Reserve Bank to lift the cash rate to 4.85 percent on Tuesday, after a seventh consecutive monthly fall in house values.
3. Pacific governments lined up behind the Marshall Islands in its pursuit of justice over United States nuclear testing, as Micronesian scholars warned that US-China military competition is running ahead of local consent.

TOP STORIES

PACIFIC-POLITICS

Rabuka delays Constitution Bill vote after mounting pressure

Sitiveni Rabuka told parliament on Monday that the Special Parliamentary Committee on the Constitution (Amendment) Bill 2026 would "table its review report at a later sitting date", reversing his confirmation a day earlier that the bill would be tabled this week. He gave no new date, saying the extension would let the committee "listen to more submissions from the public" and give parliamentary staff time to compile the final report. Rabuka has tied the absence of an announced election date to the reform process running in parallel; the hard deadline for the election is February 6, 2027.

per RNZ Pacific: "Fiji PM Rabuka delays vote on Constitution Bill after mounting pressure" · also ABC News

TRADE-ECONOMY

Markets price a fifth 2026 rate rise as house values fall for a seventh month

Markets and economists expect the Reserve Bank to push the cash rate to *4.85 percent* on Tuesday, which the Guardian records would be the fifth increase of 2026. House values fell for a seventh consecutive month in October, with the decline spreading across the country and capital city prices falling at the fastest pace of any housing downturn in four decades, on Cotality data reported by the ABC. Borrowing capacity is shrinking while rents keep rising, leaving affordability unimproved by the price falls.

per Sydney Morning Herald: "The rate rise that stops the economy? Fears of an RBA-induced recession" · also WSJ

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Albanese works the Commonwealth summit while taking heat at home for going

Anthony Albanese is at the Commonwealth Heads of Government Meeting in Antigua, where the Sydney Morning Herald reports his appearances will be carefully stage-managed as cost-of-living pressure builds at home. The ABC reports he will raise British backpacker rules with UK Prime Minister **Andy Burnham** on the sidelines, days after Canberra cut working holiday maker places. King Charles III is also attending the meeting.

per Sydney Morning Herald: "Under fire at home, Albanese walks a tightrope at Caribbean summit" · also ABC News

OVERNIGHT

AU-FOREIGN-POLICY

Burnham opens door to slavery apology as Caribbean activists press Commonwealth · ABC News

Protesters on the margins of the Commonwealth summit demanded the United Kingdom confront its role in transatlantic enslavement, which took more than 10 million Africans from their homes between the 15th and 19th centuries. **Andy Burnham** opened the door to an apology over the weekend but said the prospect of reparation payments remains unlikely. The reparations question has shadowed successive Commonwealth leaders meetings.

AU-POLITICS

Canavan presses Albanese to adopt Coalition backpacker plan · ABC News

Nationals senator **Matt Canavan** urged the prime minister to take up the Coalition's working holiday maker proposal, days after Canberra raised student visa costs and cut working holiday maker places. A regional town reliant on backpacker labour told the ABC the visa changes would cripple local businesses. Albanese is separately raising British backpacker rules at the Commonwealth summit.

AU-POLITICS

Public service AI talks deadlocked as politicians hunt staffing savings · Politico

Australian public servants are demanding safeguards on the use of artificial intelligence in government work while politicians look to the technology for savings on staff numbers, Politico reports. The negotiations are deadlocked. Machinery-of-government savings have become a live front as both major parties court budget repair arguments.

AU-POLITICS

One in four young men say violence for a cause can be justified · ABC News

New research reported by the ABC finds *one in four* young Australian men now say violence in support of a cause can be justified. The finding lands alongside separate polling showing three in four

voters believe the country is becoming more divided.

STAT OF THE DAY

4.85%

Expected RBA cash rate after Tuesday's decision

Markets and economists expect a fifth increase of 2026, landing as capital city house prices fall at their fastest pace in four decades.

Sydney Morning Herald

PACIFIC WIRE

MARSHALL ISLANDS · ISLANDS BUSINESS (STEFAN ARMBRUSTER)

Pacific states back Marshall Islands nuclear justice push

Pacific Island countries have rallied behind the Marshall Islands in its decades-long pursuit of justice over United States nuclear testing, Islands Business reports. The Marshall Islands is one of three Forum members in a Compact of Free Association with Washington and one of three that hold diplomatic relations with Taiwan.

SAMOA · RNZ PACIFIC

Samoan PM joins pro-Israel march, confirms Jerusalem embassy preparations

Head of state **Afioga Tui'malealiifano Vaaletoa Sualauvi II** and Prime Minister **La'aulialemalietoa Leuatea Schmidt** joined a "March for Israel" in Apia organised by the Samoa for Israel group. La'auli said the time had come to declare Samoa's position rather than remain undecided, and confirmed preparations for an embassy in Jerusalem continue despite opposition.

FIJI · ISLANDS BUSINESS, PACNEWS

Fiji military signals readiness to surrender coup immunity

PACNEWS reports the Republic of Fiji Military Forces is ready to surrender the immunity it holds for past coups, a provision embedded in the 2013 constitution. In the same bulletin Rabuka said the military may have to "bring things back to order" if "things go wrong", remarks made as the constitutional review timetable slipped.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · PNG POST-COURIER

Isbister takes up post as Australian High Commissioner in Port Moresby

Jamie Isbister formally assumed the role of Australia's High Commissioner to Papua New Guinea after presenting his letter of introduction to Prime Minister **James Marape**. The Post-Courier framed the arrival as a new chapter in the bilateral partnership.

REGIONAL · ISLANDS BUSINESS, PACNEWS

Progress report on the 2050 Strategy flags implementation gaps

A new Pacific report shows progress against the 2050 Strategy for the Blue Pacific Continent but warns of gaps in implementation, PACNEWS reports. The strategy is the Forum's master framework for regional cooperation and donor alignment.

REGIONAL · ABC PACIFIC BEAT

Analysts warn drug smugglers will adapt quickly to AI maritime drones

Transnational crime analysts told ABC Pacific Beat that drug smugglers will adapt quickly to the AI-enabled maritime drones being introduced for surveillance in the Pacific. A companion segment examined the

technology's rollout in Fiji.

PAPUA NEW GUINEA · ABC PACIFIC BEAT

Families of the 27 lost off East New Britain still waiting for answers

Relatives of the 27 people lost at sea off East New Britain are still without answers, ABC Pacific Beat reports. Maritime safety and search capacity have been recurring themes in PNG's domestic shipping incidents.

COOK ISLANDS · RNZ PACIFIC

Family fears for Sri Lankan woman stranded three years in Cook Islands

Ruchira Ranasingha, 50, has been stuck in the Cook Islands since November 2023 after Australia and New Zealand repeatedly refused her transit visa applications. Immigration New Zealand declined to comment on the case, citing privacy, while noting concerns about her intentions. Her family says her mental state is deteriorating.

NEW ZEALAND

NZ-POLITICS · REUTERS

Early voting surges ahead of New Zealand's November 7 election

Reuters reports a surge in advance voting before Saturday's general election. Advance voting opened on October 26 for the contest between **Christopher Luxon**'s National-led coalition with ACT and NZ First, and the opposition parties.

NZ-POLITICS · REUTERS

Two-speed economy poses election dilemma for National

New Zealand's two-speed economy, with export-facing sectors diverging from domestic demand, is complicating the governing National party's closing argument, Reuters reports, five days from the vote.

CHINA IN THE PACIFIC

MICRONESIA (FSM) · OTHER · RNZ PACIFIC

Micronesian experts urge people-first approach to US-China rivalry

Scholars and security experts told a virtual forum run by the Guam-based Pacific Center for Island Security on October 23 that military competition between Washington and Beijing must not come at the expense of Micronesia's people, environment, and sovereignty. Former Guam congressional delegate **Robert Underwood** said "military strength or military spending cannot affect everything". The forum launched the Micronesia Security Monitor, a platform tracking military activity, and discussed China's expanding maritime operations and a possible US shift toward the Second Island Chain.

CANBERRA POLITICS

AU-POLITICS · SYDNEY MORNING HERALD

Trust in politicians plunges as education divide splits voters

New polling finds three in four voters believe Australia is becoming more divided, with respondents citing broken promises and dishonesty rather than cost of living for the fall in political trust. The ABC reports the McKinnon index also recorded falling satisfaction with democracy.

AU-POLITICS · SYDNEY MORNING HERALD

Chalmers admission feeds questions about Labor's direction

Jim Chalmers has made an unusually direct admission on the government's record, the Sydney Morning Herald reports, as pressure builds on an unpopular Labor government to define itself. The ABC reports tension between the treasurer and **Anthony Albanese** over cost of living, which Chalmers has played down.

AU-POLITICS · ABC NEWS

Canavan to seek preselection for Capricornia as Ashby rules out a run

Nationals leader and Queensland senator **Matt Canavan** confirmed he will seek preselection for the House of Representatives seat of Capricornia at the next federal election. One Nation's **James Ashby** ruled out contesting the seat.

AU-POLITICS · POLITICO

Australia's campaign finance laws face a 'Citizens United' moment

Politico reports Australia's campaign finance regime is facing a constitutional challenge of the kind that reshaped United States political spending. The outcome would bear on donation caps and spending limits legislated by the current parliament.

AU-POLITICS · CANBERRA TIMES

A rare civil question time in the House

The Canberra Times records an unusually civil question time, a break from exchanges dominated by the opposition's attack on government spending. Parliament sits this week with the Reserve Bank decision landing mid-sitting.

BUSINESS AND ECONOMY

TRADE-ECONOMY · THE AUSTRALIAN

Westpac posts $6.96 billion profit, warns property slump is only half done

Westpac reported a *$6.96 billion* profit with bad loans falling despite rising interest rates, and its chief executive warned the property downturn is only half finished. The ASX 200 closed at 8,856, up 0.53 percent.

TRADE-ECONOMY · THE AUSTRALIAN

Naracoorte farmers fight rare earths push across South Australian food bowl

Farmers in the Naracoorte district are contesting a rare earths mining proposal over prime agricultural land, warning of "irreversible change". Critical minerals expansion has been central to Canberra's industrial and alliance agenda.

TRADE-ECONOMY · AFP

ExxonMobil urged to rethink Papua New Guinea gas project

ExxonMobil is being urged to reconsider its Papua New Guinea gas project, AFP reports. PNG's gas pipeline has been the subject of repeated financing and landowner disputes, with Kumul Petroleum last week saying Papua LNG financing relies on domestic borrowing.

TRADE-ECONOMY · BLOOMBERG

New Zealand assets face headwinds as the election race tightens

Bloomberg reports New Zealand assets are under pressure with the election five days away. The NZX 50 closed at 13,699, down 0.26 percent, and the New Zealand dollar fell 1.14 percent to 0.5623 against the greenback.

UPCOMING

NOV 3

Reserve Bank of Australia cash rate decision

Markets and economists expect a move to 4.85 percent, which would be the fifth increase of 2026 into a seventh month of falling house values.

NOV 7

New Zealand general election

Decides whether the National, ACT and NZ First coalition continues, and with it the current settings on defence spending and Pacific policy.

NOV 2026

Commonwealth Heads of Government Meeting, Antigua

Albanese is using the margins to press British backpacker visa rules while reparations demands dominate the host agenda.

NOV 2026

Fiji parliamentary committee report on the Constitution (Amendment) Bill 2026

Rabuka gave no date for the delayed report, and the review is the stated reason Fiji's election date remains unannounced.

FEB 6

Hard deadline for Fiji's general election

Any further slippage in the constitutional review compresses the window for campaigning and electoral administration.

THE WIRE

US-AUSTRALIA

ASPI STRATEGIST

Interoperability needs logistics: the next phase of US Marine rotations to Australia

ASPI argues the next phase of Australia-US cooperation should focus on how quickly the two can generate, deploy and sustain a combined force, linking rotational training in northern Australia to logistics capacity rather than exercise tempo alone.

TRADE-ECONOMY

ABC NEWS

ACT inflation hits 4.7 percent, above the national average

Inflation in the Australian Capital Territory rose to *4.7 percent* in the 12 months to September, above the national rate, with Canberra businesses reporting customers curbing spending.

THE AUSTRALIAN

Expert urges Queensland to abandon Borumba hydro on cost grounds

An expert called on the Crisafulli government to abandon the $18.4 billion Borumba pumped hydro project, describing the location as "a rather poor site" and putting its cost burden at six times that of Snowy 2.0.

THE AUSTRALIAN

ASIC criticises major super funds over complaint handling

The corporate regulator found major superannuation funds missed red flags in member complaints and blamed members for the funds' own errors.

CSIS Australia Chair

AUSTRALIA DAILY BRIEF

Washington, D.C.

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